SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #85 · PRAYER

“God only hears the prayers of good people.”

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Where it often comes from

Feeling too sinful or unworthy to pray. Verses about God hearing “the righteous” read as “perfect people only.” Comparing yourself with people who seem holier. Shame about recent sins. A belief that you must clean up before you can talk to God.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture says God hears the righteous, but it also shows that the righteous are not perfect people; they are humble people who turn to Him. God does not despise a broken and contrite heart. The tax collector beat his breast and asked for mercy, and Jesus said he went home justified. The LORD is near to all who call on Him in truth. Everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved. God does not wait for you to be good; He invites you to come as you are.

> *“The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit; a broken and a contrite heart, O God, You will not despise”* **(Psalm 51:17)**.

Also see

> “But the tax collector stood at a distance, unwilling even to lift up his eyes to heaven. Instead, he beat his breast and said, ‘God, have mercy on me, a sinner!’ I tell you, this man, rather than the Pharisee, went home justified. For everyone who exalts himself will be humbled, but the one who humbles himself will be exalted” **(Luke 18:13–14)**.

> “The LORD is near to all who call on Him, to all who call out to Him in truth. He fulfills the desires of those who fear Him; He hears their cry and saves them” **(Psalm 145:18–19)**.

> “For, ‘Everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved.’” **(Romans 10:13)**.

> “This poor man called out, and the LORD heard him; He saved him from all his troubles” **(Psalm 34:6)**.

Common self-statements

- God won’t listen to someone like me.
- I have to be good before I can pray.
- My sins block my prayers.
- God only hears holy people.
- I’m too far gone for God to hear me.
- I’ll pray when I get my life together.

Common logical errors

- **Misreading Scripture:** Taking “the righteous” to mean “the perfect.”
- **Labeling:** Calling yourself too bad for God to hear.
- **Comparison:** Comparing yourself to people who seem holier.
- **Avoidance:** Staying away from God until you feel worthy.

Challenging questions

- What kind of heart does God not despise?
- What did the tax collector pray, and what happened?
- Who is the LORD near to, according to Psalm 145:18?
- What does Romans 10:13 say about everyone who calls?
- Am I waiting to be good before I come to God?
- Is my sin a reason to avoid God or a reason to run to Him?
- What would I say to God right now if I believed He would listen?

Truth summary

> God does not only hear the prayers of good people. He hears the humble and broken-hearted who call on Him. The LORD is near to all who call on Him in truth. I don't have to clean up first; I can come as I am, ask for mercy, and know that He hears me.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Prayer, Answers to
- Prayer, Hindrance to
- Mercy
- Humility
- Repent

Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "God only hears the prayers of good people"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"God only hears the prayers of good people." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What kind of heart does God not despise?
- ☐ What happened to the tax collector?
- ☐ Who is the LORD near to?
- ☐ What does Romans 10:13 say?
- ☐ Am I waiting to be good first?
- ☐ Is my sin a reason to avoid God or run to Him?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God does not despise a broken and contrite heart.
- ☐ The LORD is near to all who call on Him.
- ☐ I can come to God as I am.
- ☐ God hears the humble who ask for mercy.
- ☐ Everyone who calls on the Lord will be saved.
- ☐ My sin is a reason to run to God, not away.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Psalm 51:17**
  "The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit; a broken and a contrite heart, O God, You will not despise."
- [ ] **Luke 18:13–14**
  "But the tax collector stood at a distance, unwilling even to lift up his eyes to heaven. Instead, he beat his breast and said, 'God, have mercy on me, a sinner!' I tell you, this man, rather than the Pharisee, went home justified. For everyone who exalts himself will be humbled, but the one who humbles himself will be exalted."
- [ ] **Psalm 145:18–19**
  "The LORD is near to all who call on Him, to all who call out to Him in truth. He fulfills the desires of those who fear Him; He hears their cry and saves them."
- [ ] **Romans 10:13**
  "For, 'Everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved.'"
- [ ] **Psalm 34:6**
  "This poor man called out, and the LORD heard him; He saved him from all his troubles."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Mercy prayer log:** Each day, pray one honest prayer for mercy and write: "He hears me."
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Psalm 34:6 becomes: "**Sarah** called out, and the LORD heard **her**; He saved **her** from all **her** troubles."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Mercy" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Pray the tax collector's prayer each morning:** "God, have mercy on me, a sinner," and then thank Him for hearing.
- ☐ **Read Psalm 51 slowly,** and notice how David prayed after his worst sin.
- ☐ **Pray before you "feel ready,"** and notice that God is still there.
- ☐ **Tell a trusted Christian** that you have felt too unworthy to pray, and ask them to pray with you.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "God only hears the prayers of good people": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One honest prayer for mercy
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~God only hears the prayers of good people.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You that You do not despise a broken and contrite heart. Help me reject the lie that You only hear the prayers of good people. I come to You as I am. God, have mercy on me, a sinner. Thank You that You hear me. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.